

Lesson 1: Introducing Modals

Read the story of Helen Keller below. Notice the underlined words. When you finish reading, discuss the questions that follow.

The story of Helen Keller, the girl who could not see, hear or speak

I'd like you to know the story of Helen Keller, who could neither see nor hear from the time she was a baby. Yet the brilliant girl was able to overcome all those difficulties, to graduate from a college with honours and become a useful citizen.

I must say there was nothing wrong with Helen Keller when she was born. Her father and mother were very proud of their pretty baby, who tried to say "pa-pa" and "ma-ma".



For nineteen months Helen grew bigger and stronger. She was able to walk when she was a year old; she could say a few words. But one day the child fell ill. She must have been very ill. For days she had been suffering from high fever and soon the parents learned that their darling would never be able to see and hear. When Helen was 6 years old, her parents took her to famous doctors to find out if they could do something to make her hear and see again, but the doctors could do nothing. The child was hopelessly deaf. Dr. Bell said that Kellers should write to the Perkins Institution for the blind in Boston and ask if they would send someone to help the child.

(adapted)

1. What meanings do the underlined words convey?
2. Can you understand what mood/emotion is expressed by each of these words?
3. Can you change the forms of these words?

Read the Dialogue below and notice the underlined words. A list of various functions is given in the box. In pairs discuss what function is expressed by each of the underlined words.

possibility ability permission advice strong obligation

Dialogue: A Visit to London

A: What do you think I ought to see in London first?

B: Well, historical places, I think. You should go to the Westminster Abbey, and if you can, go to the Houses of Parliament and the National Gallery.

A: And what about the British Museum? I was told one ought to see it.

B: I suppose you must go there. There you can find masterpieces of the world's best artists.

A: How can I get to the centre?

B: I think you can go by steamer down the Thames from Westminster to Tower Bridge. That's a very pleasant way to travel, and you can see the London Bridge and quite a number of buildings on the way.

[adapted]

You might have noticed that the underlined words such as *can*, *could*, *may*, *might*, *must*, *ought to*, *shall*, *should*, *will*, and *would*, do not change form for different subjects. These are special verbs which behave irregularly in English. They are different from normal verbs like 'work, play, visit' They give



additional information about the **function** of the main verb that follows it. They have a great variety of **communicative functions**. They are known as **Modals** (also called **modal verbs**, **modal auxiliary verbs**, **modal auxiliaries**)

In the story and the dialogue above, the underlined words that you have come across are examples of modals. While discussing questions 1-4 above, what characteristics of modals have you talked about?

Read about the characteristics of modals and compare them with what you have discussed.

Some characteristics of modal verbs:

- They never change their form. You can't add 's', 'ed', 'ing'.
- They are always followed by an infinitive without 'to' (except in phrases like ought to).
- They are used to express certainty, possibility, willingness, obligation, necessity, ability.

Read the dialogues below. How many modals can you find? Do they have the characteristics discussed above?

Dialogues: Asking the Way

A: Excuse me. Can you tell me where Panthapath is, please?

B: Take the second turn on the left and then ask again.

A: Is it far?

B: No, you can walk it in ten minutes.

A: Thank you very much.

B: It's a pleasure.

A: Excuse me, please. Could you tell me how to get to the Novo Theatre?

B: Sure, go straight, take the first right turn and then the second left. You can't miss it.

A: Thank you.

B: That's OK.



So, what different modals are there in English? By now you should be able to make a list of the modal verbs. Here is one:

can, could, may, might, will, would, shall, should, must

Also you must have noticed some verbs of expressions such as **dare**, **ought to**, **had better**, and **need not** in the above story or dialogues. They often behave like modal auxiliaries and may be added to the list of modals.

Remember, modal verbs are used to express functions such as:

1. permission
2. ability
3. obligation
4. prohibition
5. lack of necessity
6. advice
7. possibility
8. probability

Exercise:

Underline modals in the dialogues below. Tell your partner what function or emotion is expressed by each modal.

Dialogue 1: At Lunch

A: Would you like one more *parata*?

B: No, thanks. I'm on a diet.

A: Please, do. You've hardly eaten anything.

B: It's delicious, but I don't think I ought to.



Dialogue 2: In a Restaurant

Waiter: Can I take your order, sir?

Mr. X: Rice and vegetables for me, please.

Waiter: May I take your order, sir?

Mr. N: Yes, I'd like to try the *kebab*, please.

Dialogue 3

A: I mustn't forget to phone Jafar.

B: Why?

A: It's his birthday tomorrow.

**Dialogue 4**

A: You look tired. What's the matter?

B: It's been a very busy week.

A: You should have a good rest during the weekend.

Dialogue 5

A: Can you play tennis?

B: Yes, I can, a little. Can you?

A: No, I'm afraid, I can't, but I can play badminton quite well.

Lesson 2: Uses of Modals

Uses of *can* and *could*

Work in pairs. Tell your partner what you can do now using the computers and the Internet. Also talk about what you were not able to do when computers and the Internet were not a part of your life.

Notice how you have used *can/can't* and *could/couldn't* in your talk. What differences do you notice between *can* and *could*?

Read the review of a new model of mobile phone. Make a list of the things you can do with this phone.

This is a good looking phone with a removable plastic back panel. This phone comes in three colours. If white isn't your colour, you can get the S5 model in black or green, depending on your choice. It has a big 5.1 inch screen and a 13 megapixel camera. This camera produces good quality pictures. One important feature of this stylish phone is the finger print sensor. The users are able to make online payments using this set. The phone is also water resistant.

(adapted)



Read the dialogues below and discuss the questions that follow.

Dialogue 1

A: Hello, friend. I need some help with my typing.

B: What type of help do you need?

A: I have to type a text in Bangla but I don't know how to type in Bangla.

B: No problem, I can help you with that. It's easy to type in Bangla. I can type 50 words per minute now.

A: That's great. How long have you been practising it? In fact I could not type in Bangla even two years ago. But I practised hard and now I can type quickly and easily.

Dialogue 2

A: Hello, friend, Can you help me?

B: Sure. What can I do for you?

A: My phone is out of balance and I need to call my home now.
Could I use your mobile phone?

B: Certainly, here is my phone.

Have you noticed the various ideas/modes expressed by *can/could*? Discuss the following questions:

- a. How do the speakers in Dialogue 1 talk about their past and present abilities/inabilities?
- b. How do the people in Dialogue 2 talk to give or ask for permission?

Now, read the following section to know more about the uses of *can/could*.

The modal auxiliary *can* is used

- to express **ability** (in the sense of being able to do something or knowing how to do something): He can speak Spanish but he can't write it very well.
- to express **permission** (in the sense of being allowed or permitted to do something): Can I talk to my friends in the library waiting room?

- to express **possibility**: (in the sense that something may happen)
Bangladeshi cricketers can do better if they play more international matches.

The modal auxiliary **could** is used

- to express an **ability** in the past:
I could run five miles when I was young.
- to ask for **permission**:
Could I borrow your laptop for an hour?
- to express present **possibility**:
We could spend the afternoon just sitting around and talking.
- to express **possibility** or ability within a given condition:
If he studied harder, he could pass the exam.

Exercise 1

Complete the sentences below with can/could. Also discuss the meaning expressed by can/could in each sentences. You need to use the negatives (can't/couldn't) where necessary.

1. She doesn't want to go to the swimming pool because she swim.
2. We are going to the cinema tonight. You come with us if you want to.
3. Excuse me, Sir please tell me where the railway station is?
4. I am sure she play the guitar better when she was younger.
5. It is hot in here,you open the window, please ?
6. He worked so hard ! He pass his exam if he had not missed his train and got there late.
7. Oh Mom! You have made a cake! I smell it when I entered the kitchen.

Uses of *may* and *might*

Read the sentences below and notice the uses of *may/might*. Discuss in pairs the functions of *may* and *might* in each sentence.

1. Take your umbrella as it may rain today.
2. He is still at work! He may come home late I'm afraid.
3. Jamil couldn't repair his fridge; he might have asked his neighbour.
4. They talked too loudly. They might have woken the baby!
5. Look at those clouds! It may rain in a minute.

Now, read the section below to check when and where we use *may/might*.

Might is the past tense of *may* when used in the context of granting or seeking permission. Also note that *might* is considerably more uncertain than *may*.

Example:

- May I leave class early?
- If I finish all my work, I might leave early.

Exercise 2

Fill in the blanks with *can/could/may/might* as needed:

1. They (can/might) be away for the weekend but I'm not sure.
2. You (may/might) leave now if you like.
3. (Could/May) you open the window a bit, please?
4. He (can/could) be a foreigner. He speaks differently.
5. (May/Can) you play the piano?
6. They (can't/may not) still be out! There is light in their room.
7. Let's hope, tomorrow (can/could) be a sunny day. It has been raining for a few days.
8. You (can/might) be right but I'm going back to check anyway.

Uses of *should*, *must* and *have to*

Ann is asking Tom for advice on going to Russia. It is her first time to travel abroad. Now read the dialogue between Anne and Tom and notice the uses of *should/must/have to*.

Tom: Hey Ann, you look worried. What's up?

Ann: Well, I 'm a little worried about going abroad for the first time. It's Moscow and I'm a bit unsure of things. You've been there, haven't you? Can you tell me what I need, or give me some advice or something?

Tom: Yeah, I have been there a few times. Well, you must have a passport, but I guess you have it.

Ann: Yes, I have one. What else do I need?

Tom: You have to get a visa from the Russian embassy.

Ann: Well, that s fine. Is there anything else I need to know?

Tom: Well, it's winter and Moscow can become very cold, so you should take some warm clothes with you.

Ann: OK, thanks. You've given me a lot of information.

[adapted]



It's 8.15 am and the school starts at 8.00 am. Tohin's mother is talking to him. Notice how she uses *should/must/have to*.

1. You must be at school by this time.
2. You stay away from school, it's bad for your education. It's also against the rules.
3. You don't have to take a bus, I'll drive you to school.
4. You should go to bed earlier at night. You'd feel more relaxed in the morning.

Read the following situations and fill in the gaps with *should/must/have to*:
Ratan looks very pale and tired.

1. He rest a little before supper. It would do him good.
2. He study so hard, he knows his lessons very well.
3. He try to be less scared of tests. He wouldn't suffer so much.
4. He be very worried about tomorrow's Maths exam.



Rosy said she would invite me to her party but she didn't.

1. She make false promises.
2. You get offended, she may have forgotten to ring you up.
3. You think there's something wrong with you. It was Rosy's mistake.
4. If you don't go to her party, you buy her a present.

Look, there's going to be heavy rain soon.

1. We hurry home. I think it would be better and safer.
2. We stand under a tree. It's not safe.
3. Look, there's a man selling umbrellas. We buy one.



Discuss in pairs when and where you may use *must/should/have to*. Then read the section below to check your understanding.

Must is the most commonly used modal to express certainty. It can also be used to express necessity or strong recommendation, although people often use the form '*have to*'.

One may use *must not* to prohibit actions, but this sounds very strong or rude. It is better to use softer modal verbs such as *should not* or *ought not* to discourage something rather than to prohibit.

Examples:

- This **must** be the right address! (certainty)
- Students **must** pass an admission to study at this school. (necessity)
- You **must** take some medicine for that cough. (strong recommendation)
- Jenny, you **must** not play in the street! (prohibition)

Must not vs. Do not have to

Must not suggests that you are prohibited from doing something. *Do not have to* suggest that someone is not required to do something.

Examples:

- You **must not** eat that. (It is forbidden, it is not allowed.)
- You **don't have to** eat that. (You can if you want to, but it is not necessary)

Should is most commonly used to make recommendations or give advice. It can also be used to express obligation as well as expectation.

Examples:

- When you go to Agra, you **should** see the Taj. (recommendation)
- You **should** focus more on study and less on games. (advice)
- I really **should** be in the class by 9.00 am. (obligation)
- By now, they **should** already be in Dhaka. (expectation)

Have to is used to express *certainty*, *necessity*, and *obligation*.

Examples:

- This answer **has to** be correct. (certainty)
- The milk **has to** be stirred continuously to prevent burning. (necessity)
- They **have to** leave early. (obligation)

Ought to is used to advise or make recommendations. *Ought to* also expresses assumption or expectation as well as strong probability, often with the idea that something is desirable. *Ought not* (without 'to') is used to advise against doing something.

Examples:

- You **ought to** stop smoking. (recommendation)
- Robi **ought to** get the promotion. (It is expected because he deserves it.)
- This piece of land **ought to** increase in value. (probability)
- You **ought not** waste your time. (advice against doing something)

Exercise 3

Complete the sentences using the italicized words below. Positive and negative forms can be used. Some gaps may have more than one answer:

must ***have to*** ***might*** ***ought to*** ***should***

1. Ruma said you didn't need to buy her anything for her birthday, but I really think you..... at least get her some flowers.
2. Deeba said she was really busy this week, but I think she..... show up at the party.
3. Yoube joking! That can't be true.
4. For most people, learning a language is not so easy. You practise the language regularly.
5. I would love to go on the cruise on the Buriganga with some of my classmates. But such a luxurious trip be expensive.
6. We to get permission from the Headmaster if we want to organize a picnic.

Uses of *shall*, *will* and *would*

Make five promises expressing your strong willingness or determination to do something.

Example: I shall never be late at school.

Promises to keep

1.
2.
3.
4.
5.

Now, read the following sections to know about the use of *will/would*.

In certain contexts, *will* and *would* are interchangeable, but there are differences. Notice that the contracted form *'ll* is very frequently used for *will*.

Will can be used to express willingness:

- I'll wash the dishes if you dry them up.
- We're going to the movies. Will you join us?

It can also express intention (especially in the first person):

I'll do my exercises later on.

It can also express prediction:

- specific: The meeting will be over soon.
- timeless: Too much rain will destroy crops.
- habitual: He will eat bananas in the morning.

Would can also be used to express willingness:

- Would you please take off your coat?

Look at the table and see the meaning, function and uses of modals

Modals	Meaning	Expressing	Example
must	to have to	strong obligation	I <i>must</i> stop when the traffic lights turn red.
	to be very probable	logical conclusion (deduction)	He <i>must</i> be very tired after such enormous work
must not	not to be allowed to	prohibition	You <i>must</i> not smoke in the hospital.
can	to be able to	ability	I can swim
	to be allowed to	permission	<i>Can</i> I use your phone please?
	it is possible	possibility	Smoking <i>can</i> cause cancer!
could	to be able to	ability in the past	When I was younger, I <i>could</i> stay up all night and not get tired.
	to be allowed to	more polite permission	Excuse me, <i>could</i> I just say something?
	it is possible	possibility	It <i>could</i> rain tomorrow!
may	to be allowed to	permission	May I <i>use</i> your phone, please?
	it is possible, probable	possibility, probability	It <i>may</i> rain tomorrow!
might	it is possible	weak possibility	I <i>might</i> come and visit

	probable	probability	You might be in America next year if I can save enough money.
need	necessary	necessity	<i>Need</i> I say more?
need not	not necessary	lack of necessity/ absence of obligation	I <i>need</i> not buy any tomatoes. There are plenty in the fridge.
should/ ought to	<i>used to say or ask</i> what the correct or best thing to do	moderate obligation	I <i>should</i> / <i>ought</i> to see a doctor. I have a terrible headache.
	<i>to suggest</i> an action or to show that it is necessary	advice	You should / ought to revise your lessons.

Exercise 4

Complete the sentences using the words listed in the box below. Don't forget to capitalise when necessary. Some gaps may have more than one correct answer.

<i>can</i>	<i>could</i>	<i>have to</i>	<i>must</i>	<i>might</i>	<i>should</i>
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1. Akram's flight from Rome took more than 11 hours. He be exhausted after such a long flight. He prefer to stay at home tonight and get some rest.
2. When you have a small child in the house, youleave small objects lying around. Such objects hurt the child.

3. Amjad:you hold your breath for more than a minute?

Nasim: No, I can't.

4. Joyeta's engagement ring is enormous! It have cost a fortune.

5. Please water my plants while I am away. If they don't get enough water, they.....die.

6. I speak Arabic fluently when I was a child and we lived in Saudi Arabia.

7. Youtake your umbrella along with you today. The weather forecast said thererain later of this afternoon.

8. Oh no! Faisal's wallet is lying on the dining table. He have left it here last night.

9. I was reading the book last night before I went to bed. I never took it out of this room. Itbe lying around here somewhere. Where it be?